

Nibble: Planning a Thesis Shoot

The real paperwork from a short film I produced, from prospectus to picture wrap.

A horror-comedy short about a pet rock that eats everyone in the house. Written, directed, shot, edited and sound-designed by Feralucce Savage as an MFA thesis film. Shot in August 2024, delivered October 2024. I was also its associate producer, unit production manager and location manager.

18

weeks of preproduction

4

shoot days, plus a pickup day

48

scenes, 16 2/8 pages

\$4,750

cash budget, all in

33

of 44 budget lines covered without cash

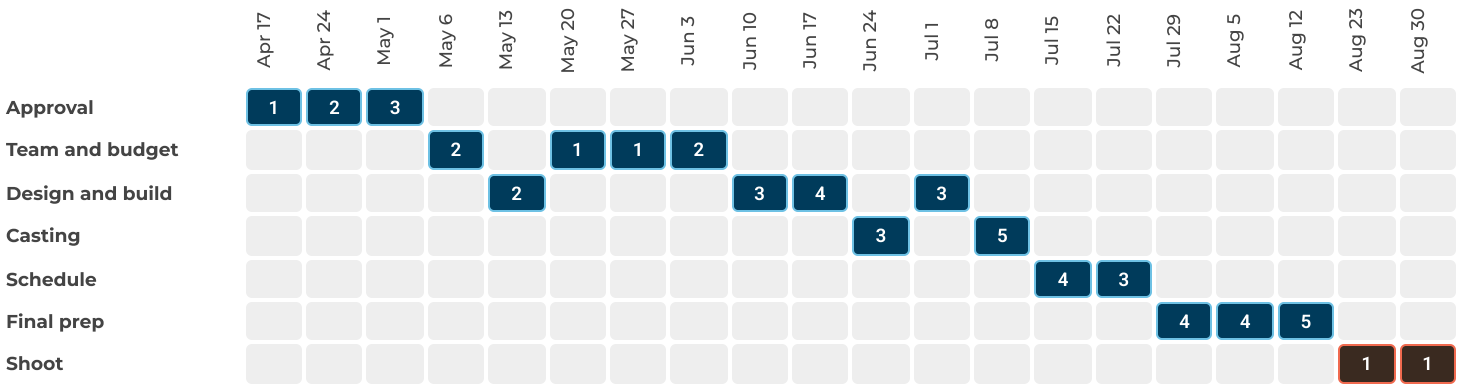
Transcribed from my MFA thesis appendix (University of New Orleans, 2024). Names, the production address and phone numbers are removed; people are shown by role.

1

PREPRODUCTION

Eighteen weeks, week by week

The plan I wrote in April and worked to. Each square is a week with work in that phase; the number is how many tasks. Hover a square for the tasks.



The full schedule, as written

Four days, one actor per day

The stripboard in shooting order. Each lead's scenes are grouped into one day (a Nell day, a Suzie day, a Dani day), so each lead works once, and the child actor's limits fit a single day. The playback scenes shoot first though they come last in the script, and the notes are the ones I wrote on the board.

☐ Day interior
 ☐ Day exterior
 ☐ Night interior
 ☐ Night exterior
 ☐ TV playback

46	Playback: the commercial	PLAYBACK	6	3/8
47	Playback: Bernie Baxter's haunted TV studio	PLAYBACK	7	4/8
48	Playback: the science lab <i>Note: The playback on the TV is the first scene we are shooting - it is the last scene in the script.</i>	PLAYBACK	8, 9	1 5/8
End of Day 1 of 4 · Playback day · Thu Aug 22 · call 4:00 p.m. · 2 4/8 pages				
12	Dani's house	DAY EXT · MORNING	2	2/8
14	Dani's house	DAY EXT	2	1/8
16	Dani's house	DAY EXT	2	2/8
26	Dani's house	DAY EXT · EVENING	—	1/8
13	Dani's house	DAY INT	2, 5	1/8
15	Dani's house	DAY INT	2, 5	1/8
9	Dani's kitchen	DAY INT	2, 5, 8, 9	1 5/8
27	Dani's bathroom	DAY INT	2	2/8
28	The hallway outside the bathroom	DAY INT	5	2/8
29	Dani's bathroom: the shower	DAY INT	2, 5	5/8
End of Day 2 of 4 · Nell day · Fri Aug 23 · call 7:00 a.m. · 3 6/8 pages				
7	Dani's kitchen: the dog bowls <i>Note: Animal Actor - Most likely the hardest scene of the day - scheduling it first to make the day easier.</i>	DAY INT	3, 5	3/8
8	Dani's house	DAY EXT	3	2/8
17	Dani's house: the doorbell	DAY EXT	4	1/8
19	Dani's house: Suzie at the door	DAY EXT	4	4/8
21	Dani's house	DAY EXT	4	1/8
25	Dani's house: the scream	DAY EXT	4, 10	2/8
18	Dani's house	DAY INT	5	1/8
20	Dani's living room	DAY INT	4, 5	3/8
22	Dani's living room	DAY INT	4, 5	6/8

23	Dani's bedroom	DAY INT	4	3/8
24	Dani's hallway	DAY INT	4	2/8
End of Day 3 of 4 · Suzie day · Sat Aug 24 · call 7:00 a.m. · 3 4/8 pages				
2	Dani's house: the box	DAY EXT	1	2/8
1	Dani's living room	DAY INT	1	2/8
3	Dani's kitchen: opening the box	DAY INT	1, 5	7/8
4	Dani's bedroom	DAY INT	1	2/8
5	Dani's kitchen	DAY INT	5	3/8
6	Dani's house: Dani drives off <i>Note: Has to be during daylight - can't shoot first, costume change.</i>	DAY EXT	1	1/8
31	Dani's house	DAY INT	1	3/8
32	Dani's hallway	DAY INT	1	2/8
33	Dani's bathroom	DAY INT	1	2/8
34	Dani's hallway	DAY INT	1	2/8
35	Dani's bathroom	DAY INT	1	2/8
37	Dani's bathroom	DAY INT	1	2/8
38	Dani's hallway	DAY INT	1, 5	1/8
39	Dani's bathroom	DAY INT	1, 5	5/8
41	Dani's living room	DAY INT	5	2/8
42	The hallway outside the bathroom	DAY INT	5	2/8
43	The hallway outside the bathroom	DAY INT	5	2/8
44	Down the hallway toward the bathroom	DAY INT	5	1/8
45	The hallway outside the bathroom	DAY INT	5	2/8
36	Dani's hallway	DAY INT	5	1/8
40	Dani's house: the scream	DAY EXT	1	1/8
10	Dani's house: Dani pulls in	NIGHT EXT	1	1/8
30	Dani's house: Dani's car pulls in	NIGHT EXT	1	2/8
11	Dani's kitchen: time passes <i>Note: This is a special lighting shot, MAY shoot on another day if we have time.</i>	NIGHT INT	5	2/8
End of Day 4 of 4 · Dani day · Sun Aug 25 · call 7:00 a.m. · 6 4/8 pages				

Columns: scene, set, type, cast numbers, pages in eighths. Cast: 1 Dani; 2 Nell; 3 Crusher (dog); 4 Suzie, the girl scout (child actor); 5 Nibbles (the rock); 6 Announcer; 7 Bernie; 8 Jeanine; 9 Doctor Compton; 10 Crossfade element (as listed on the board).

Each lead on set once

Read from the board: every human lead is SWF, starting, working and finishing on the same day. With a volunteer cast and a child actor, that keeps each lead's time on set to a single day.

CAST	DAY 1 Playback day	DAY 2 Nell day	DAY 3 Suzie day	DAY 4 Dani day	DAYS
1 · Dani				SWF	1
2 · Nell		SWF			1
3 · Crusher (dog)			SWF		1
4 · Suzie, the girl scout (child actor)			SWF		1
5 · Nibbles (the rock)		SW	W	WF	3
6 · Announcer	SWF				1
7 · Bernie	SWF				1
8 · Jeanine	SW	WF			2
9 · Doctor Compton	SW	WF			2

\$4,750, and everything that didn't cost cash

Built in EP Budgeting (Movie Magic) and kept as delivered. Cash went only where nothing could be borrowed, donated or made: the location, meals, the script supervisor, wardrobe and props, drives, and festival entries.

11

cash lines

20

pro bono lines

10

students lines

3

lent or provided lines

Locations		\$1,800
Publicity		\$1,300
Production staff		\$900
Video		\$300
Wardrobe		\$245
Props		\$170
Story and rights		\$35

ACCT	CATEGORY (OPEN FOR THE LINES)	CASH
Above the line		
1000	Story and rights	\$35
1100	Producers	\$0
1200	Directors	\$0
1300	Cast	\$0
<i>Total above the line</i>		<i>\$35</i>
Production		
1600	Production staff	\$900
1800	Camera	\$0
1900	Wardrobe	\$245
2000	Make-up and hair	\$0
2100	Set dressing	\$0
2200	Props	\$170
2300	Art department	\$0
2500	Video	\$300
2600	Sound recording	\$0

ACCT	CATEGORY (OPEN FOR THE LINES)	CASH
2700	Set lighting	\$0
3100	Locations	\$1,800
	<i>Total production</i>	<i>\$3,415</i>
Post-production		
3400	Editing	\$0
3800	Titles	\$0
	<i>Total post-production</i>	<i>\$0</i>
Other		
4000	Publicity	\$1,300
	<i>Total other</i>	<i>\$1,300</i>
	<i>Total above the line</i>	<i>\$35</i>
	<i>Total below the line (production, post and other)</i>	<i>\$4,715</i>
Grand total (fringes \$0)		\$4,750

What changed, and what it taught me

From my thesis reflection, with the lessons in my own words.

WHAT HAPPENED	IMPACT	RESPONSE	LESSON
PRE-PRODUCTION Script feedback: readers and industry professionals asked for the two leads to share a scene.	The film's concept changed. Set dressing, wardrobe and props bought for the original look no longer fit, and neither did the location.	Made the change, returned most purchases and found a new location. Storyboards survived, because the previs hadn't encoded the palette changes.	In retrospect, the right choice: it produced the most touching scene I've filmed.
PRE-PRODUCTION The actor the lead was written for had to be out of the country, about a month before the shoot.	The lead role was uncast four weeks out.	Recast the part.	—
PRE-PRODUCTION The 3D print of the largest rock failed four times; the hand-sculpted fix cracked the resin when heat-cured.	The hero prop wasn't ready.	Repaired it twice; the paint dried minutes before leaving for set.	—
PRODUCTION The new location was booked solid, so there was no tech scout.	On arrival it was smaller than the photos and full of reverb. Planned jib shots were impossible, the bathroom was too small, and the crash pad didn't match the hall floor.	Went handheld for the jib shots.	No location without a tech scout.
PRODUCTION The camera fell.	The camera broke and a couple of files were corrupted.	A pickup day.	—
PRODUCTION The dog didn't like the food bought for it and wouldn't eat.	The hardest scene of the day got harder.	It was already scheduled first in the day, as the hardest scene.	Don't write a scene with an animal unless I can hire a well-respected trainer.
PRODUCTION The practical effects failed: the blood shooter, the shower curtain, a modesty garment that wasn't opaque.	The effects didn't work as planned on the day.	—	Hire someone for practical effects; directing, shooting and running a blood rig at once is too much.
PRODUCTION Working with a child actor.	The parent expected a three-page scene to take 30 minutes.	All of the child actor's scenes were scheduled into one day.	Don't write a part for a child actor; the limits are extremely restrictive.

WHAT I'D DO DIFFERENTLY

Put at least one lighting instrument on every shot. Shoot above the delivery resolution, to allow reframing. Tech-scout every location before booking it. Hire practical effects, and an animal trainer, rather than doing it all myself.